



AP PHOTO/SUCHETA DAS



CHIDAMBARAM (FAR LEFT) BELIEVES HIS POLICY ON MAOISTS (LEFT) WILL YIELD RESULTS EVEN AS SECURITY FORCES REMAIN WOEFULLY ILL-EQUIPPED TO FIGHT THEM

official. According to him, they will seriously want to talk only when they are under extreme pressure, which will happen only after security forces manage to kill or nab one of their senior ideologues like Ganapathi or Koteswar Rao alias Kishenji. "We are still a long way from talks. After verifying the seriousness of their offer, we have to get reactions of all the state governments concerned. Some like Jharkhand may want to engage them directly. Some may want the Centre to do it. Some like West Bengal may not want to talk at all," he added.

Also, even if the two come to the negotiating table, what would they talk about? "The Maoists are wanted in many cases. Whatever their excuse be—ideology or wresting power—they cannot be given amnesty," said another MHA official. Moreover, it could also be a Maoist ploy to buy time to recuperate, regroup and strengthen their forces. "This is what the

## The Battle Within

- All affected states are not on board with some going soft on the rebels.
- Armed with outdated weapons like .303 rifles, state police forces are ill-equipped to tackle the Maoists.
- Poor training and fitness levels of police forces.
- States are short by about four lakh security personnel.
- Lack of proper infrastructure in camps with no barbed wire fencing or lighting for perimeter defence.
- Security personnel are battling diseases like malaria as well as Maoists.

People's War Group had done when the Andhra government engaged them. Talks did not prove to be an effective method of tackling them. The Greyhounds (a specially created task force in the state) did," he added.

The Maoists may not yet be under severe pressure but they are feeling a bit of it nevertheless. Operation Green Hunt, the Centre's joint operation with state governments, and direct confrontation have taken the war to a different level, forcing them to carry out bigger attacks. The home minister said he had expected the situation to get worse before it improves. "As long as we did not engage them, they were happy and kept expanding. They will continue to expand unless we challenge them. We need a strong head, a stronger heart and staying power," Chidambaram said. According to him, the most difficult aspect of handling the Maoist menace was that most states did not have well-